QUEST FOR **BULLSEYE**

THE TARGET: The 10m air pistol event is an incredible test of the minutest accuracy. The bullseye, called the 10-point ring, is just 4.5mm, the size of a peppercorn

THE SCORE: At the Olympics, the boards are electronically operated and the aim is to hit dead centre of this tiny dot with scores ranging from a maximum of 10.9 for a perfect shot and a decimal variation of 10 if the shot hits within the circle measuring 11.5mm

PRELIMINARY ROUND: In an Olympics final, only eight shooters qualify, and the competition is determined in two stages. In Stage 1, each shooter gets two series of five shots each with 250 seconds to complete a series

THE ELIMINATION: After 10 shots in Stage 1, shooters have to fire 14 shots on command with a 50-second time limit for each shot. The elimination process begins after the second shot in this round with the shooter with the lowest combined score (including Stage 1) bowing out

THE SCORES: Subsequent eliminations happen after every two shots and end with the 24th shot, determining the gold and silver medalists. Cumulative total scores determine the final rankings. In Paris, Manu was placed third after 22 shots and won the bronze, missing silver by 0.1 points



"[OLYMPIC] *MATCH KE BAAD EK DOOSRE KI LAAT KHEENCH RAHE THHE* (PULLED EACH OTHER'S LEG AFTER THE MATCH)"

–SARABJOT SINGH
Manu's partner in the 10m air pistol mixed team event in Paris where the duo won a bronze

stop thinking," recalls Manu. "I couldn't control and channelise my thought process at all." By the time she reached Stage 2 of the mixed team qualification, Manu blanked out. "I seemed to have entirely forgotten how to shoot, what my technique is, what I do to have a good shot. I'd forgotten the process, I was so clueless, I felt really disappointed in myself, like how could you do this, how could this happen?" Her sub-par performance dragged down the combined total with teammate Saurabh Chaudhary, leaving them in seventh position and costing India, firm favourites until then, a spot in the finals of an event that had been introduced just that year. In her final event, 25m pistol, after a strong start in the first stage of qualification, her nerves entered the fray in the last 10 shots of the second stage. "As soon as it was over, all the things that had happened...I felt like everyone was making fun of me."

Taking a break, she thought, would perhaps help her get over the Tokyo nightmare. She went for a holiday to south India with her parents. But she still couldn't stop thinking about the sport. "I was holding a kettle full of water and practising my stance in the hotel," she says. There was no forgetting the setback, but Manu had also made a bold declaration in a post-Games interview to the Olympic Channel. Close to tears, she had signed off saying, "Next time I will win, and you will see." Manu cannot stand losing. Anshika Satendra, her bestie and a fellow pistol shooter, knows that all too well. "She is fearless and stubborn," Anshika says of Manu. "If she decides she wants it, then she wants it."

Turning a senior in 2023 was a moment of reckoning for Manu. Doubt seeped in as she consistently struggled to find a spot in the national team in 2022-23 against talented youngsters like Esha Singh, Rhythm Sangwan, Palak and Simranpreet Kaur Brar. She wanted her place back, for which she needed her consistency back. Barring an Asian Games team gold in 25m pistol in 2023, individual glory had eluded her. Moreover, the statement in Tokyo haunted her. "I realised I needed to do something about it. I kept going because I felt *keh ke nahin karna, sharm si aane lag gayi* [to say it and then not do it had begun to get embarrassing]."

BORN TO SHOOT

Born to Ramkishan and Sumedha Bhaker, a chief engineer in the merchant navy and a teacher, respectively, Manu grew up in a household where she and her elder brother Akhil followed their mother's "army school-like schedule". TV time was restricted to 30 minutes and the kids were taken to play only after finishing homework. Sport was always encouraged. Manu tried kabaddi, tennis and skating, contact sports like karate and boxing, and the Manipuri martial art thang-ta, even winning national medals in the latter. "I wanted to learn self-defence," she says, and "be strong and feel powerful. I didn't want anyone to dominate me in any way."

Shooting, though, was more an outcome of serendipity than design, of punishment in fact. As a student at the Universal Senior Secondary School in Goria, the 14-year-old Manu was reprimanded for either "sleeping or eating" (she can't remember which) during history class and asked to leave the classroom.